

**ARSI**

The Amateur Radio Society of India is a non-profit public service organization, organized under the laws of the Government of India

**NIAR**

National Institute of Amateur Radio was established in 1983 by the Ministry of Communications

# Amateurs: The real masters

**From Sonia Gandhi to Amitabh Bachchan, several eminent personalities are HAM radio operators. We find out how you can get started as an amateur radio enthusiast**

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**S**imply put, any amateur radio is referred to as “HAM radio” and the operators are termed as “Hams”. By definition the term amateur would imply that the radio and its operator are either committed to helping communities or pursue it out of individual interest without any ambition of financial compensation unlike commercial radio operators. The term amateur is not a reflection of the capabilities of the system or the skill of the operator. It indicates that the operators are committed to helping communities without financial gain. This also helps as a classification basis for the license, where enthusiast licenses (for Hams) are cheaper than commercial licenses.

Ham radio operators usually enjoy personal communication with each other and can support their communities during emergencies or disasters while learning more about electronics and radio communication theory.

The culture of operating Ham Radios unlike other similar socio-technical activities (like Geo-Caching) is not new. Even though the first license was granted in India as early as 1931 it became popular and omnipresent only after 1984 in India, when the then Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi lifted the import duty for wireless equipment. As of 2008 estimates there are more than 16000 operators in India and around six million worldwide.

Amateur radio operators help the community at large during disaster situations like floods, earthquakes, cyclones

or whenever ‘normal’ communication systems fail. Ham radio operators provide emergency communication to their communities. Apart from that they also participate in contests. This is called the sport of Ham radio. Hams go on air and compete to see who can make the most contacts in a specified time interval. Some lucky hams get to speak to astronauts since space stations have Ham radio equipment and some astronauts use them to make contact with the hams on earth. There are also satellites which bounce Ham signals across the globe so you could speak to people from the other side of the globe.

Since there is no censorship board for amateur radios there are two generally accepted guidelines that are followed, think of them as fair-use policies:

1. Hams are not allowed to do anything with their radios for personal financial gain. Ham radio is a hobby.
2. Ham radio operators cannot ‘broadcast’ to the public. This means that Ham radio transmissions are meant to be received by other Ham radio operators. While a short-wave radios will allow you to listen to the Ham radio

bands, what you will hear is hams talking to other hams and not music or other radio programs of ‘general’ interest.

Note: Ham radio operators are designated or known by their call signs. These call signs consist of a country code, and a unique identification number. A call sign is the identity of the Ham operator, and is issued by a central regulatory authority.

## Use in relief work

Indian amateur radio operator, Bharathi VU4RBI, demonstrated amateur



Bharathi Prasad demonstrating the Ham at DX-pedition

radio to local students in Port Blair, Andaman Islands, a few days before the 2004 Indian Ocean earthquake, and subsequent tsunami. In India, Vigyan Prasar (a science promotion body under the Indian Department of Science and Technology) coordinates simulated disaster communication exercises and also organises training to help people get a Ham radio license in areas that are vulnerable to natural calamities.

A team of Ham radio operators were at Port Blair on Andaman Island on a ‘Dx-Expedition’ when the tsunami struck in December 2005. Mr. Sarat Babu recounts how he was able to contact 12,000 people on the mainland and all over the world and help the Government understand the ground situation when all other communication links were cut. The exemplary services he rendered during the crucial 10-day period brought him recognition in the form of the International Humanitarian Award.

The Amateur Radio Society of India has been instrumental in leading amateur radio DX-peditions to the remote island territories of India in the Indian Ocean. In December, 2004, a team of amateur radio operators embarked on an ARSI-organised DX-pedition to the

